

New Dimensions of Influence

How trusted insight shapes
boardroom decisions

In partnership with

NIKKEI

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Foreword



JON SLADE
CEO,
FINANCIAL TIMES

Today's business leaders are not short of information; they are drowning in it. But knowing what to trust has become complicated.

Too many vested interests are pulling trusted information in the wrong direction. That is partly a result of algorithmically driven business models. It is partly because there are incentives to produce information that is inflammatory. And it is partly because society is not concerned enough about why trusted information matters.

Who can business leaders trust? And why?

Our new report explores where senior business leaders are turning for trusted insight, and what they do once they find it.

It builds on the findings in last year's FT x IPA global study, Bridging the Trust Gap, which found that trust is the second most powerful business driver — yet only one in five companies treat it as a board-level KPI.

This year, our research underlines the importance of trusted information as leaders demand greater transparency from AI-generated content and reliable sources that can shape and test their thinking.

It reinforces the impact of trust as currency for brands like the FT. And why we are all responsible for building a trusted information ecosystem.

New Dimensions of Influence

With objectivity at a premium, trust has become both a strategic necessity and an active discipline.

Our 2025 research, Bridging the Trust Gap, found that half of organisations are now measuring trust, and nearly one in five are tracking it at board level. In 2026, those figures are largely unchanged. What has changed is the amount of time leaders spend figuring out who and what to trust.

Why are business leaders struggling to identify insight they can trust at a time of information abundance? How do they filter for the most relevant intelligence? And what do they do once they find it?

We surveyed 532 Financial Times readers from business leadership roles and interviewed 12 senior business leaders to find out which sources they turn to for trusted information. The research tells us that trusted insight is not simply consumed; it challenges assumptions, provides proof, shapes decisions and prompts action.

● The point

85% of business leaders are concerned that AI-generated content makes it harder to tell what is credible

Leaders are **5x** more likely, when they look for information they can use, to go directly to a small set of trusted publishers than they are to rely on AI tools or platforms/feeds

10x Accuracy, evidence and independence matter 10 times more than speed and timeliness as signals of trust

More than **1/3** say they are suffering from information overload

#1 When they trust a piece of information, leaders are most likely to use it to challenge their assumptions and reconsider their position

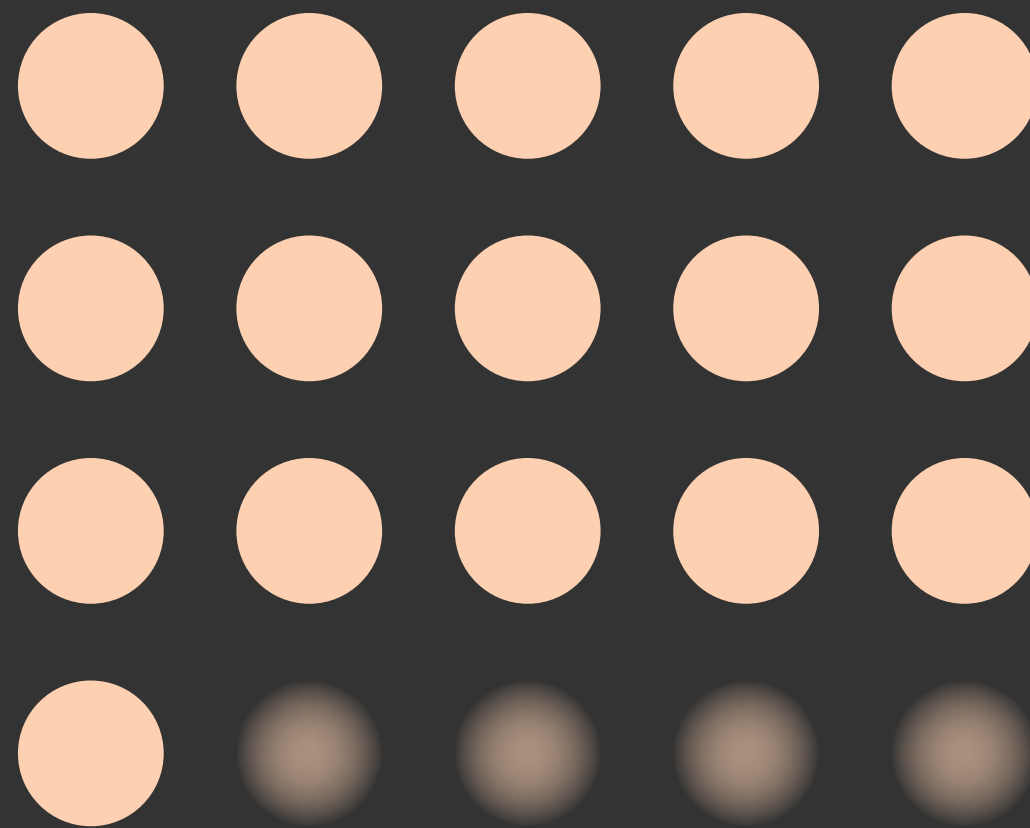
1. The **trust** defect

Business decision-makers are inundated by more sources, channels and formats than ever before. Podcasts, YouTube videos and AI-generated content have added to the noise competing for their attention.

This access has not resulted in clarity. “One of the challenges of this hyper-information system that we live in, with all of these different platforms and sources of information, is that we try to consume all of it and then try to make sense of all of it,” says Finola McDonnell, Chief Communications and Marketing Officer at the Financial Times. “And it’s too difficult.”

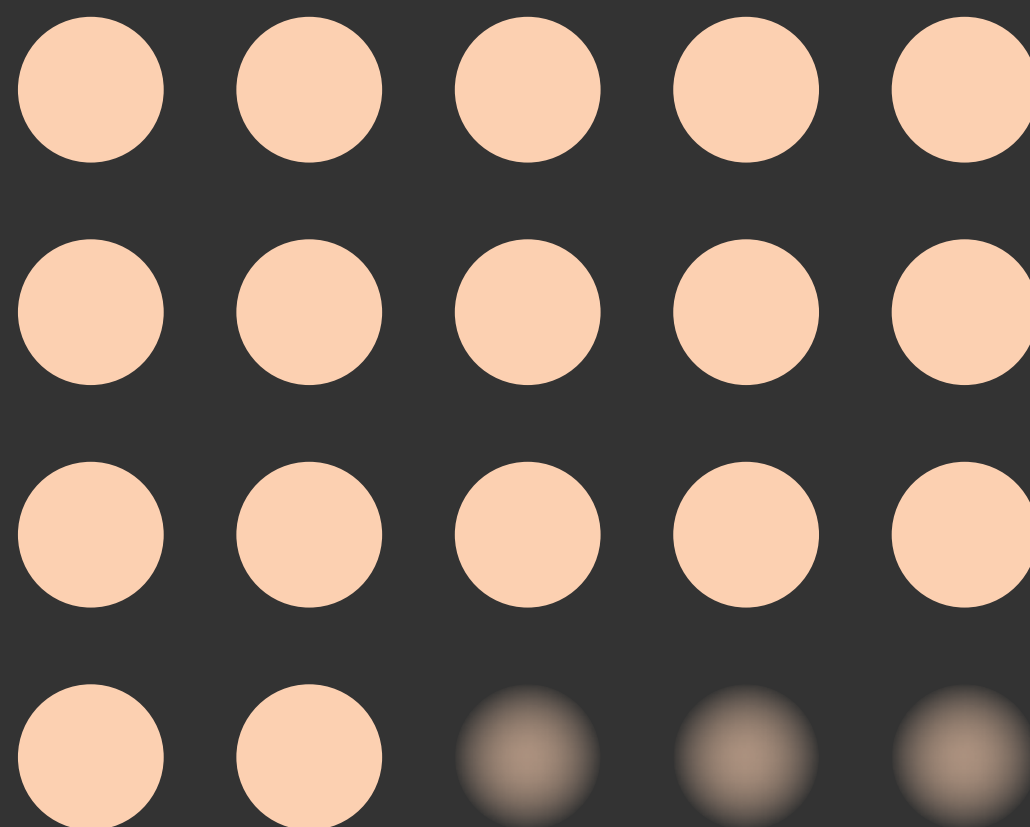
The rise of news creators and influencer-led content has shifted the information environment. This flourishing creator economy, combined with low levels of trust in business leaders, journalists and politicians, is reshaping who and what people turn to for trusted insight.

Leaders must now work harder to filter signal from noise, misinformation and disinformation.



80%

of business leaders say trusted sources are more important for strategic business decisions than they were two years ago



85%

believe the business environment is becoming more volatile and uncertain, so context now matters more

A practical response to risk

The World Economic Forum's 2026 [Global Risks Report](#) ranks misinformation and disinformation as the second-biggest short-term risk globally. The ability to identify credible, contextual and decision-ready information is now a core part of how businesses manage that risk.

Business decision-makers are becoming more selective about the sources they rely on, the voices they listen to and the information they are prepared to bring into strategic decisions.

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There is a real impact on the cognitive load in the management sphere. So the degree to which we can preserve that for decisions that need to be made – the ones with real business impact – is what will improve management and leadership overall.

BEN WIENER
GLOBAL HEAD,
COGNIZANT MOMENT

“

The sheer amount of rubbish that is out there in terms of media information content – highly opinionated, biased, ill-informed articles, opinion bleeding into factual reporting – it's very, very confusing. And I think for that reason trust has deteriorated in our industry.



MATT FOTTRELL
CHIEF READER REVENUE OFFICER
AND PRESIDENT, US,
FINANCIAL TIMES

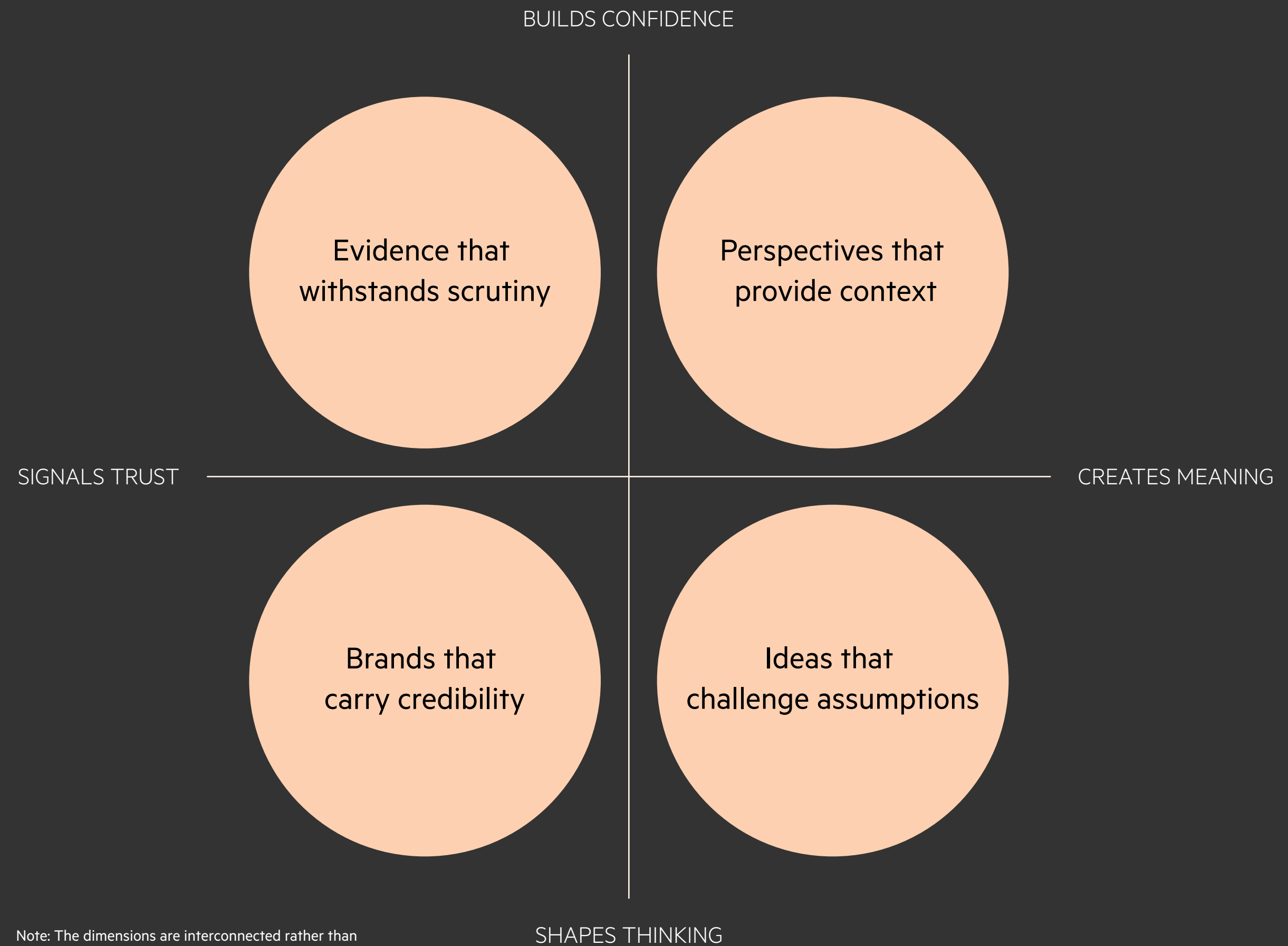
2. The four dimensions of influence

Influence is now being shaped by leaders' more demanding expectations. It is no longer enough for a source to be visible, timely and familiar.

Our research shows that there are four dimensions that business leaders are filtering for before they trust information to influence their decisions.

The four dimensions of influence

Influence begins when evidence, context, challenge and credibility combine to shape how leaders think and act.



Note: The dimensions are interconnected rather than mutually exclusive. The map shows where each dimension plays its strongest role in the influence journey.

Dimension 1:
Evidence that withstands scrutiny

In an environment where misinformation spreads quickly and opinion is often presented as fact, leaders are looking for insight that will withstand scrutiny. Claims must be supported, sources must be clear and views must be independent.

Accuracy is particularly crucial: most leaders say it is more important than speed when the stakes are high.

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Independence, alongside history and brand, is an important part of any source of information.

KUNIYUKI MAKIE
MANAGING DIRECTOR, MEDIA AND
BUSINESS SOLUTIONS,
NIKKEI

77% of business decision-makers say they now verify information across multiple sources more than they used to

Evidence, accuracy and independence are ranked by business leaders as the three most important characteristics of a trusted source



Q. What are the most important characteristics of a trusted source?

Dimension 2: Perspectives that provide context

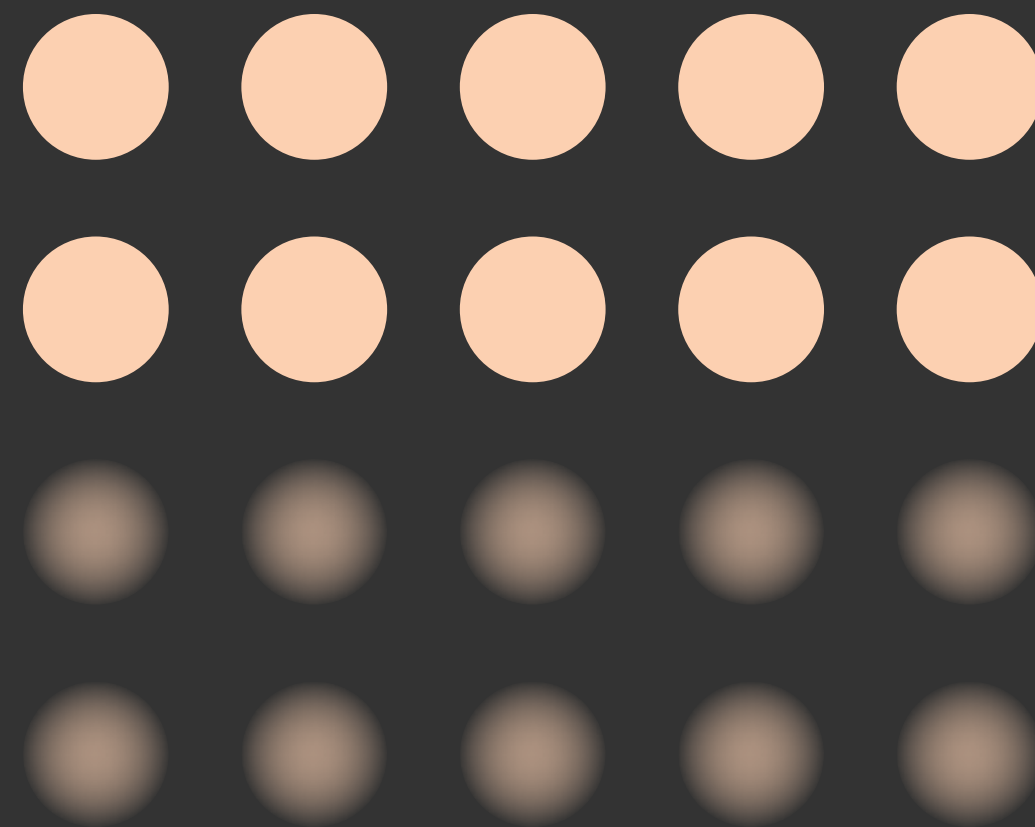
Faced with endless content, decision-makers are turning to their peers for context, connection, perspective and challenge. This human layer is becoming more important as AI-curated content proliferates: leaders need intelligence they can interrogate before they use it to guide their decisions.

“

When we're swamped with content across multiple channels, sometimes it's a human being who might be able to guide you in a certain way.

LIESL SMITH

CHIEF MARKETING OFFICER,
FREEDOMPAY



50%

of business decision-makers say
that peer conversations hold just as
much value as trusted sources when
it comes to informing decisions

Dimension 3: Ideas that challenge assumptions

Trust is built through rigour. But echo chambers, misinformation and AI-generated algorithms can create blind spots and reinforce biases. Leaders value information that tests their thinking so they can base their decisions on evidence.

82% of business decision-makers say they trust a source that challenges their assumptions more than one that aligns with their existing views

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I don't want more of the same. I want to pick up fresh perspectives. I want to find that stuff that I don't know. If all information is to reinforce what I already know, then it loses its value.

BAS VAN BUIJTENEN
CEO,
LTS LOHMANN THERAPIE-SYSTEME



Dimension 4:
Brands that carry credibility

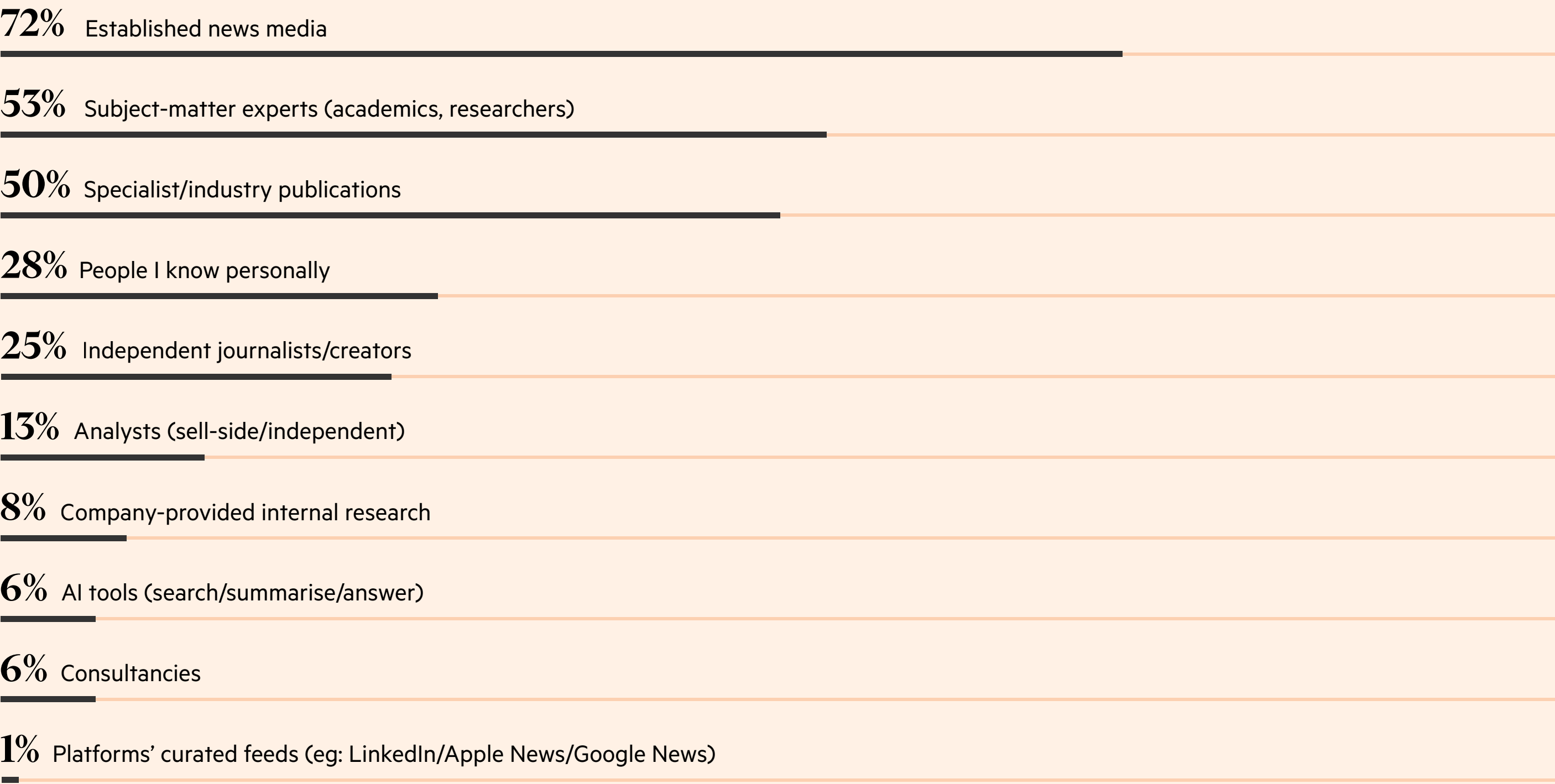
Trusted brands act as a shortcut to confidence. They are an important filter for time-poor leaders who need to cut through huge numbers of sources, channels and formats. By turning to organisations that have already earned credibility, these leaders reduce the burden of validation and identify valuable intelligence more quickly.

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Increasingly, I’m thinking of quality brands as being like a kitemark for truth and trust in a world in which content is proliferating and the provenance and credibility of it is less clear over time.

NICK FALLON
CHIEF STRATEGY AND DEVELOPMENT OFFICER,
FINANCIAL TIMES

45% of business decision-makers say their first-choice route to decision-relevant information is to go directly to a small set of trusted publishers

Asked which sources they trust most to provide reliable, decision-relevant information, leaders point to the brands, people and publishers they already know

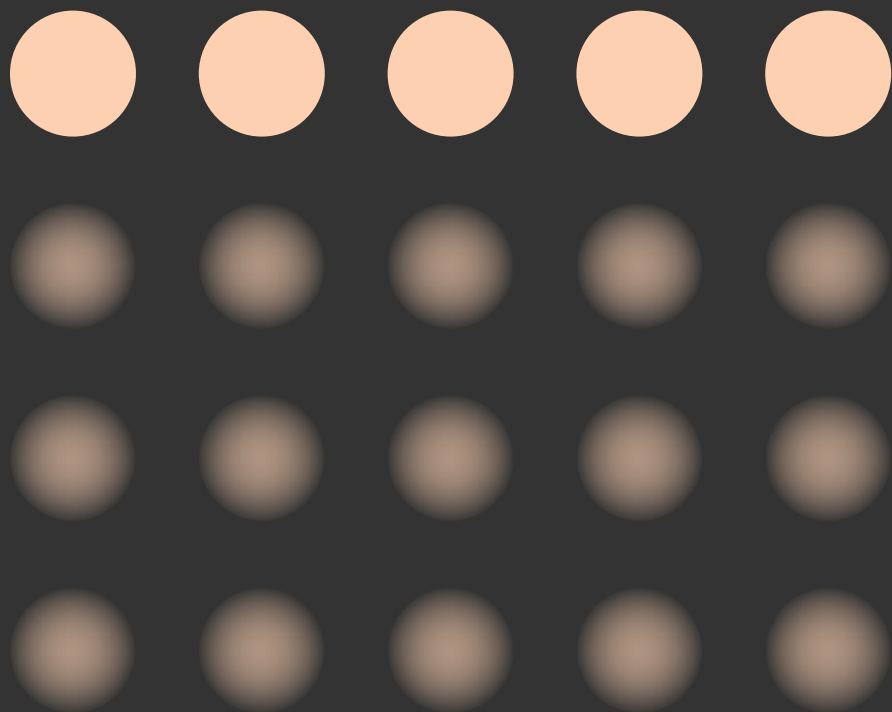


Q. Which do you trust most to provide reliable information for strategic business decisions?

3. The fast track to impact

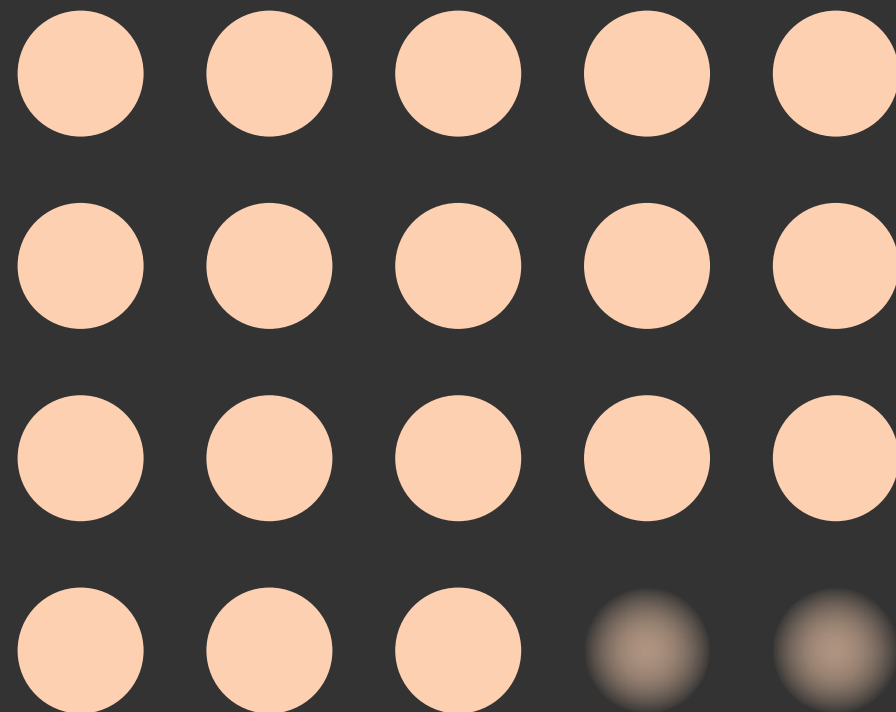
Time-poor leaders’ biggest challenge is how to apply the right filters at speed. About a quarter of decision-makers are now using AI to help them surface and analyse often vast quantities of information, and nearly half expect this to increase in the near future.

But AI has not yet earned authority as a source of influence in its own right. Most leaders say it can make sources harder to trace, blur the line between fact and misinformation, and increase the risk of missing context.



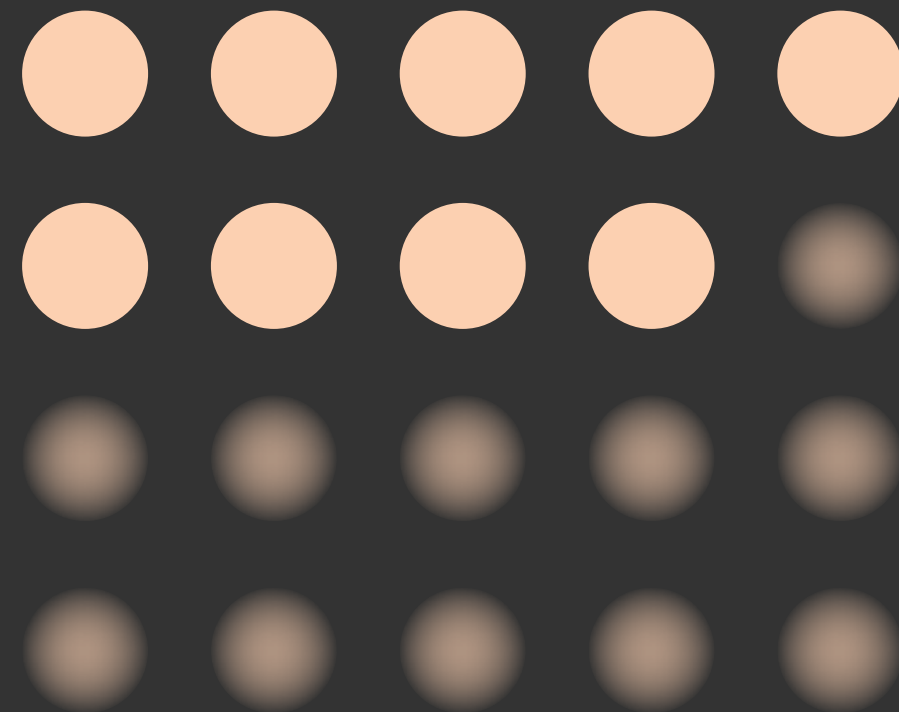
26%

of decision-makers currently use agentic AI to curate and brief them on topics they care about



88%

say that AI increases the risk of missing nuance or context



43%

believe senior leaders will use AI tools more to summarise and synthesise information in the next two years

Will we ever rely on AI?

For AI to shift from unreliable substitute search engine to trusted source of insight, senior leaders say they need clear citations, independent editorial oversight and a human review option.

The way the technology is used also has a significant impact on its usefulness and reliability among senior leaders and in the boardroom. Instead of outsourcing thinking to AI, LinkedIn Co-founder and venture capitalist Reid Hoffman advises leaders to “use it as a counter agent”. Some of the senior leaders we spoke to share that view: they say they use AI as a tool to stress-test ideas and help organise their thinking.

“I would always recommend that people ask follow-up questions just as you would in a conversation,” says Bas van Buijtenen, CEO at LTS Lohmann Therapie-Systeme. “And never stop at the first answer the engine spits out at you.” That caution seems sensible: some are raising concerns that over-reliance on AI tools to instantly answer questions and solve complex problems could harm human intelligence.

“

There is the danger that AI confines our viewpoints, confines our thinking or reinforces what we already think we know very well. And then, depending on who’s using it, it becomes more and more polarised and makes decision-making more treacherous.

ANGELA MACKAY

CHIEF COMMERCIAL OFFICER AND MANAGING DIRECTOR,
ASIA-PACIFIC
FINANCIAL TIMES



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I would very rarely read an AI summary of a document and then feel confident that I can speak credibly about it. It would just be a part of that filtering process that helps me understand whether it is worth my time to go a bit deeper.

NICK FALLON

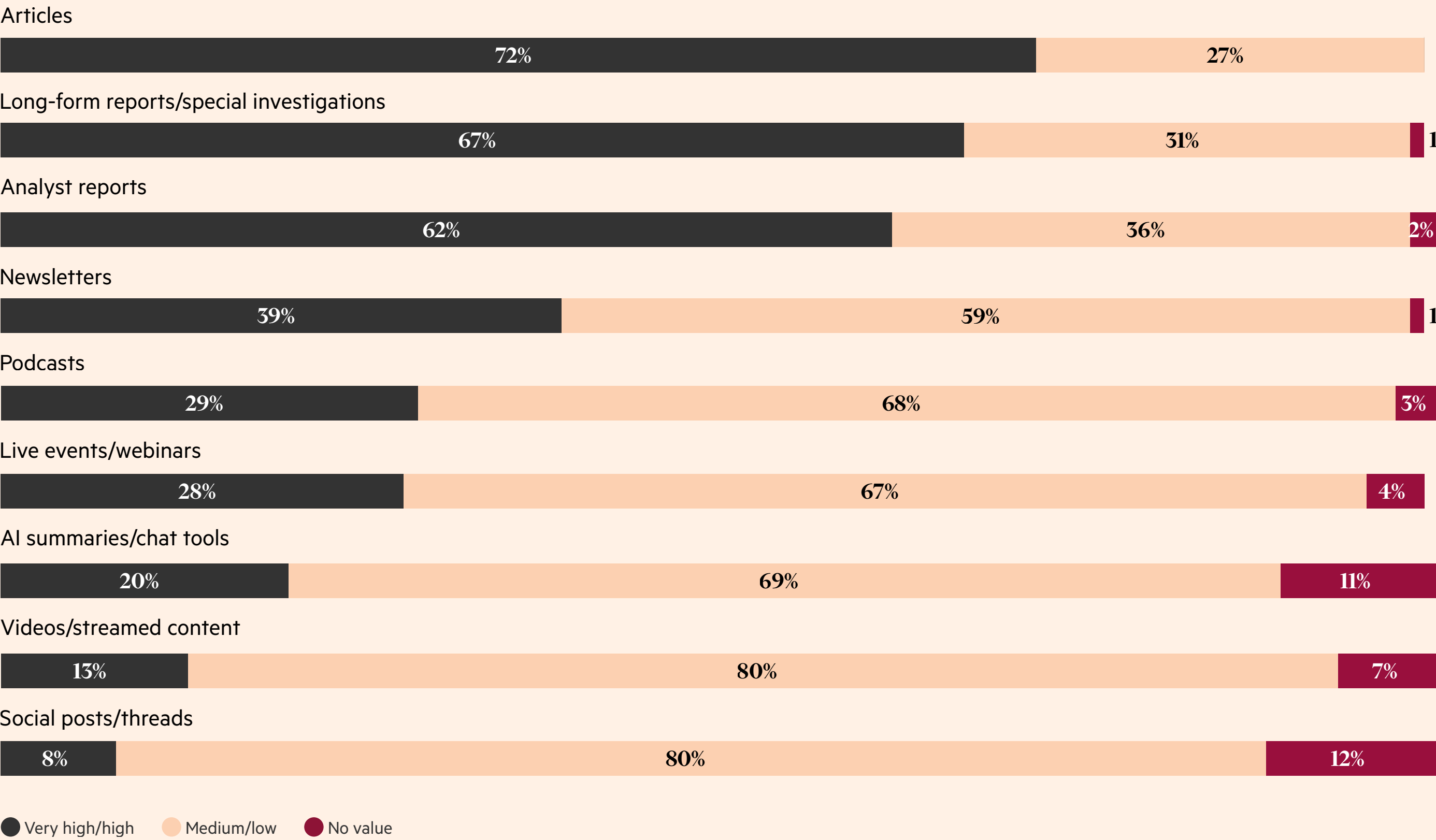
CHIEF STRATEGY AND DEVELOPMENT OFFICER,
FINANCIAL TIMES



What do you need in order to trust an agentic AI to curate and brief you on topics that guide strategic decisions?

- “
- “I am not sure that 100 per cent trustworthy AI has arrived yet... or [if it] will. It is too open to manipulation.”
- “I have only used it to collect sources, which I then read independent of the AI verbiage.”
- “It only regurgitates accepted norms and thinking, rarely challenging assumptions I know to be false.”
- “Considerable pre-existing expertise in the field under examination.”
- “Trust but verify.”

When it comes to their decision-relevant value, articles, long-form content and reports far outweigh other formats; more than one in 10 say AI and social media have no value



Q. For each of the formats listed, please select the value it has in helping you to make strategic business decisions.

There is a belonging reflex

As a counterbalance to an increasingly AI-heavy information environment, many decision-makers are turning to peer networks and community forums for connection.

“There’s a hyperlocal trend, which is the rise of region-specific subscription products and very niche newsletters that you come to trust because it feels like the people who are compiling them have the right information sources to help you,” explains the Financial Times’ Finola McDonnell.

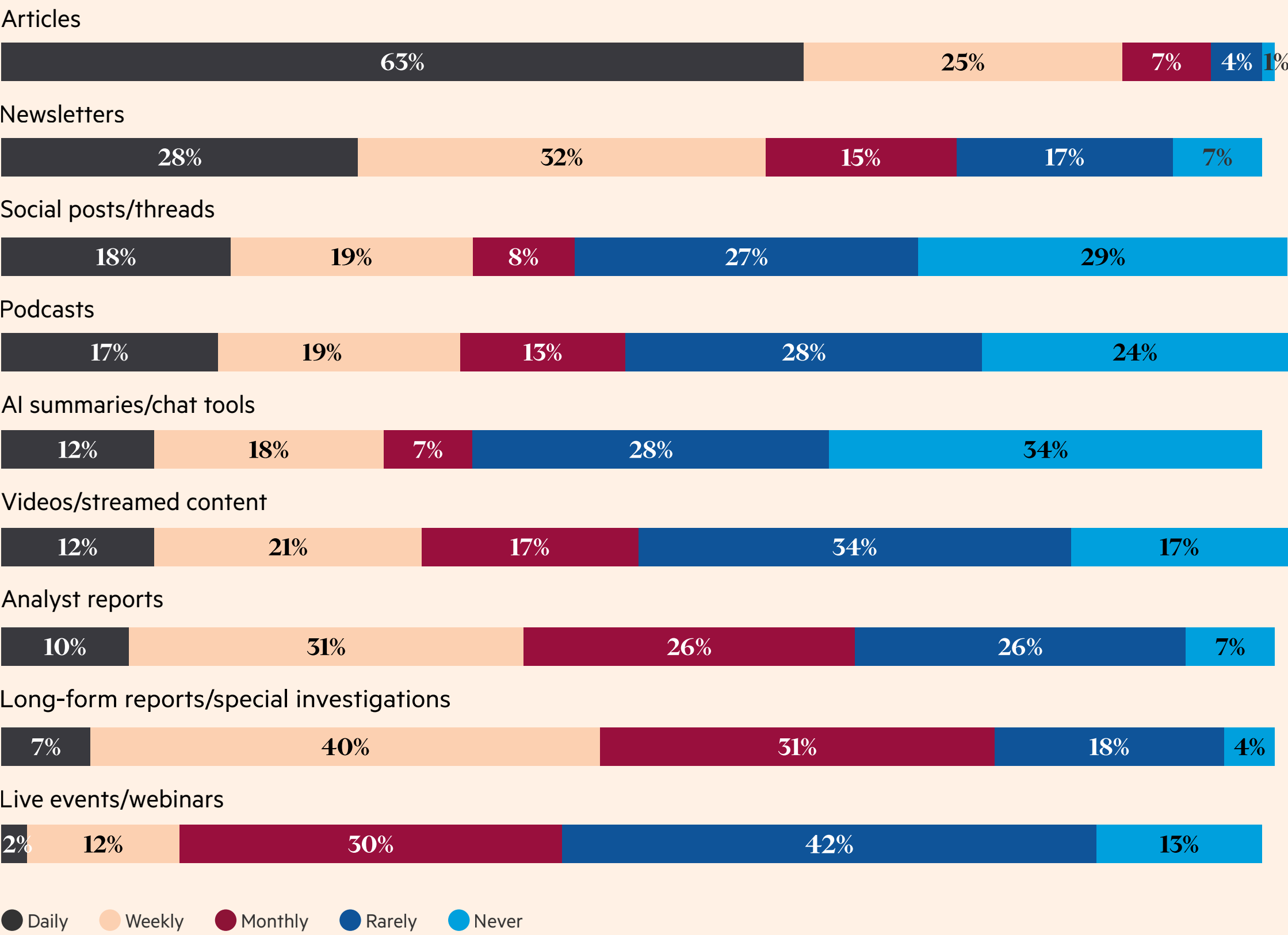
From events and networking meetups to expert-authored newsletters and Substack posts, these human forums give leaders trusted environments for knowledge-sharing and a deeper sense of belonging. They also signal a shift away from a platform era, in which content is surfaced at speed, to a community era, where the focus is on building trusted relationships to keep audiences engaged.

“There’s little more emblematic of belonging than turning up to something in real life,” said journalist Sarah Ebner in an article in Nieman Lab. “And many news organisations have realised the power of events, both emotionally and commercial[ly].”

“I’m consuming a lot more via audio and I have found that to be highly effective for the way that I split my time as a very busy executive. The media partners that are evolving to understand those changing consumption patterns are also where we’re looking for partnership.

TARA GIULIANO
CHIEF MARKETING
OFFICER,
NUVEEN

To stay informed, business leaders turn daily to articles and weekly to long-form reports and newsletters; more than a third never use AI



Q. For each of the formats listed, please select the frequency with which you use it in a work context.

4. The axis from trust to **action**

Almost all leaders will act on insight when they decide it is decision-relevant.

“

Most of the investment decisions that come to the board – from aircraft to major infrastructure like terminals – take 10, 15 years to confirm the business case and realise. We always take a forward-looking view and we challenge the business case to understand whether it’s sensitive or elastic enough to what could happen in the future.

LAWRENCE FONG
DIRECTOR DIGITAL AND IT,
CATHAY

Here are the five most-cited use cases for trusted information, according to our research:

01

Validate decisions

Trusted insight gives leaders confidence that their decisions are based on evidence instead of just instinct.

02

Challenge assumptions

Credible insights improve judgement by helping leaders to stress-test their thinking, revisit their assumptions and consider alternative perspectives.

03

Act faster

When a source is trusted, leaders can move from awareness to action with greater confidence. This reduces the validation burden.

04

Share with networks

Credible insight travels. It helps leaders to brief teams, inform peers and shape conversations in a way that widens their spheres of influence.

05

Elevate to leadership

The strongest insights become boardroom material. Decision-makers use them to frame risks and evaluate strategic choices.

A final word

In the battle for attention, leaders are looking for individuals or institutions that will act as a shortcut to valuable insight.

With a business and economic environment that is dramatically different from just 12 months ago, decision-makers are trying to formulate a new way to access, make sense of and act on information. Many are working overtime to balance their trust in their instincts with optimism about new possibilities.

“We’re moving into a post-social era,” explains the Financial Times’ Finola McDonnell. “We will come back to the basics of ‘What do I need to know in business?’ Because there’s a difference between what is nice to know when we go home and sit on the sofa and what we needed to know during the day. We shouldn’t lose sight of that.”

The consequences for business decisions, brand credibility and personal reputation are significant. Trust and influence come down to the company a leader keeps: whose opinion and expertise they choose to cite, challenge and counter when it matters most.

About the research

Conducted by
FT Global Commercial Strategy and Insight Team

Methodology
Online survey carried out in English

Source
FT Feedback Forum reader panel

Date of survey
March and April 2026

Sample size
532 respondents

A note on the data
Due to rounding, data may not add up to exactly 100 per cent

Qualitative insights

The following executives and experts participated in qualitative interviews for this report:

Nick Fallon, Chief Strategy and Development Officer, Financial Times

Lawrence Fong, Director Digital and IT, Cathay

Matt Fottrell, Chief Reader Revenue Officer and President, US, Financial Times

Tara Giuliano, Chief Marketing Officer, Nuveen

Angela Mackay, Chief Commercial Officer and Managing Director, Asia-Pacific, Financial Times

Kuniyuki Makie, Managing Director, Media and Business Solutions, Nikkei

Finola McDonnell, Chief Communications and Marketing Officer, Financial Times

Jon Slade, CEO, Financial Times

Liesl Smith, Chief Marketing Officer, FreedomPay

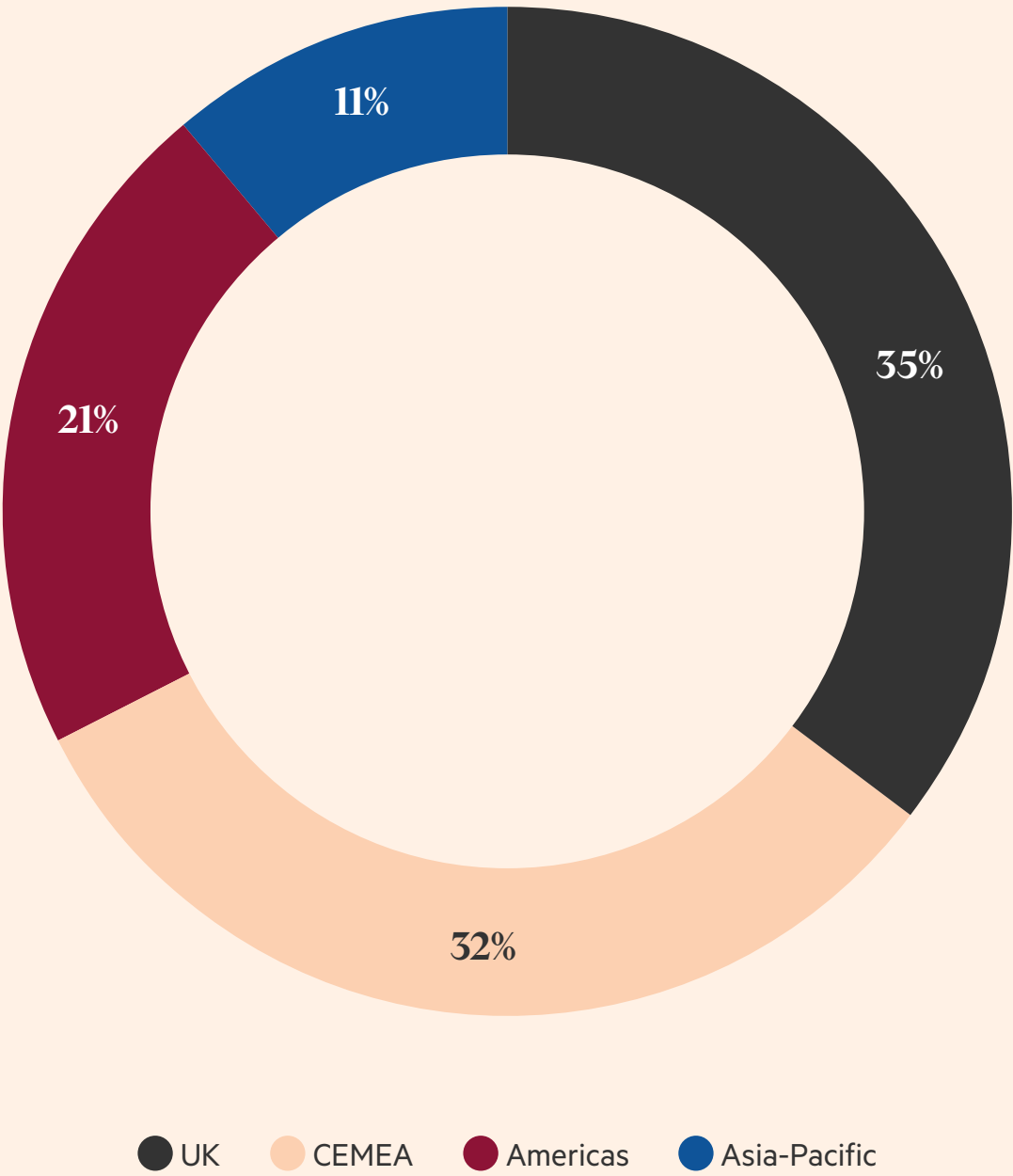
Hiroshi Toyofuku, Managing Director, Nikkei Europe

Bas van Buijtenen, CEO, LTS Lohmann Therapie-Systeme

Ben Wiener, Global Head, Cognizant Moment

Respondent demographics

Region

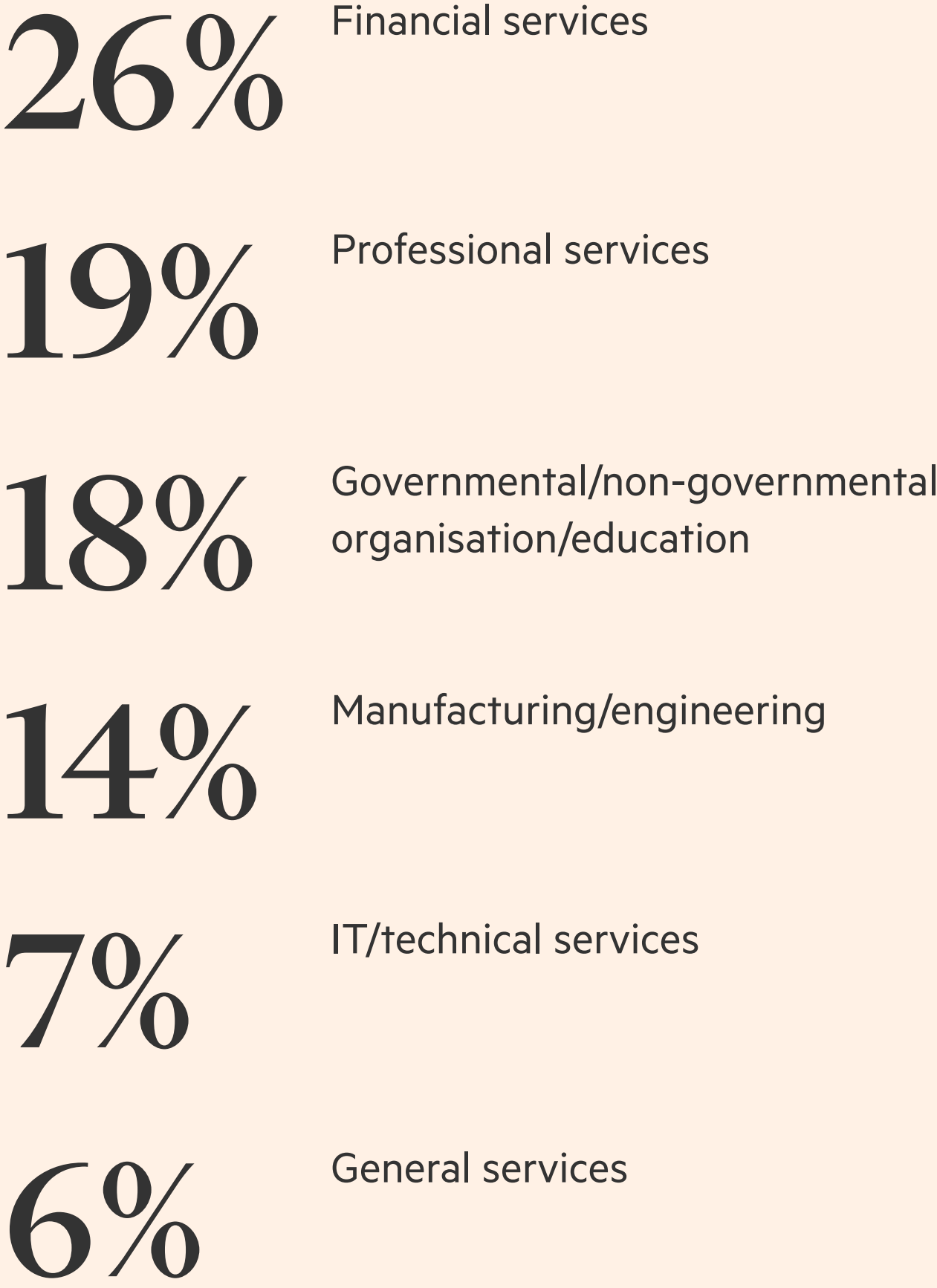


Seniority



Respondent demographics

Sector



Job role



Company size



In a world of information abundance, influence belongs to those who can provide clarity, context and credibility. Through rigorous thought leadership and access to highly engaged decision-making audiences across journalism, digital platforms and live experiences, the Financial Times helps organisations contribute meaningfully to the conversations that shape business decisions.

commercial.ft.com/campaigns/influence-contact